

BAY

Crises, setbacks, obstacles—these will certainly be met by any executive in the course of his career. The measure of a man in such circumstances is not only how he copes with adversity, but also how he turns it to his advantage. Business is always a battle—for sales, improvements, efficiency

—and an executive must lead very much as a general would: to win.

I remember learning as a youth an invaluable lesson from a man who even then had extensive business holdings and who later became one of America's wealthiest industrialists. Although I knew him fairly well, I hadn't seen him for several months before bumping into him one day in the lobby of a Chicago hotel.

"How are things going?" I asked him after we'd exchanged the customary greetings.

"Not good—terrible, in fact," he replied with a placid smile. "One of my companies has been shoved into a tight corner by the competition. Another is operating in the red

—and a third hasn't the cash to meet its short-term debts that fall due this month."

"You certainly don't act as though any of it worries you very much," I remarked in surprise. I found it hard to believe that any businessman who was in so much apparent trouble could be so casual about his problems.

"Hell, Paul, I'm not in the least bit worried," he answered. "To tell you the truth, I needed something like

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this to get me up on my toes; everything had been going entirely too smoothly for far too long. An occasional crisis is good for a businessman. There's no better exercise for him than to have a few messes to clean up every now and then."